Let’s Make a Mini Crossword!

2026-04-29

Is this presentation for you?

You may be interested in this presentation if:

- You are already familiar with the concept of "American-style" crosswords.
- You want to create a crossword using the standards prescribed by major crossword publishers.
- You are looking for a quick how-to rather than theory.

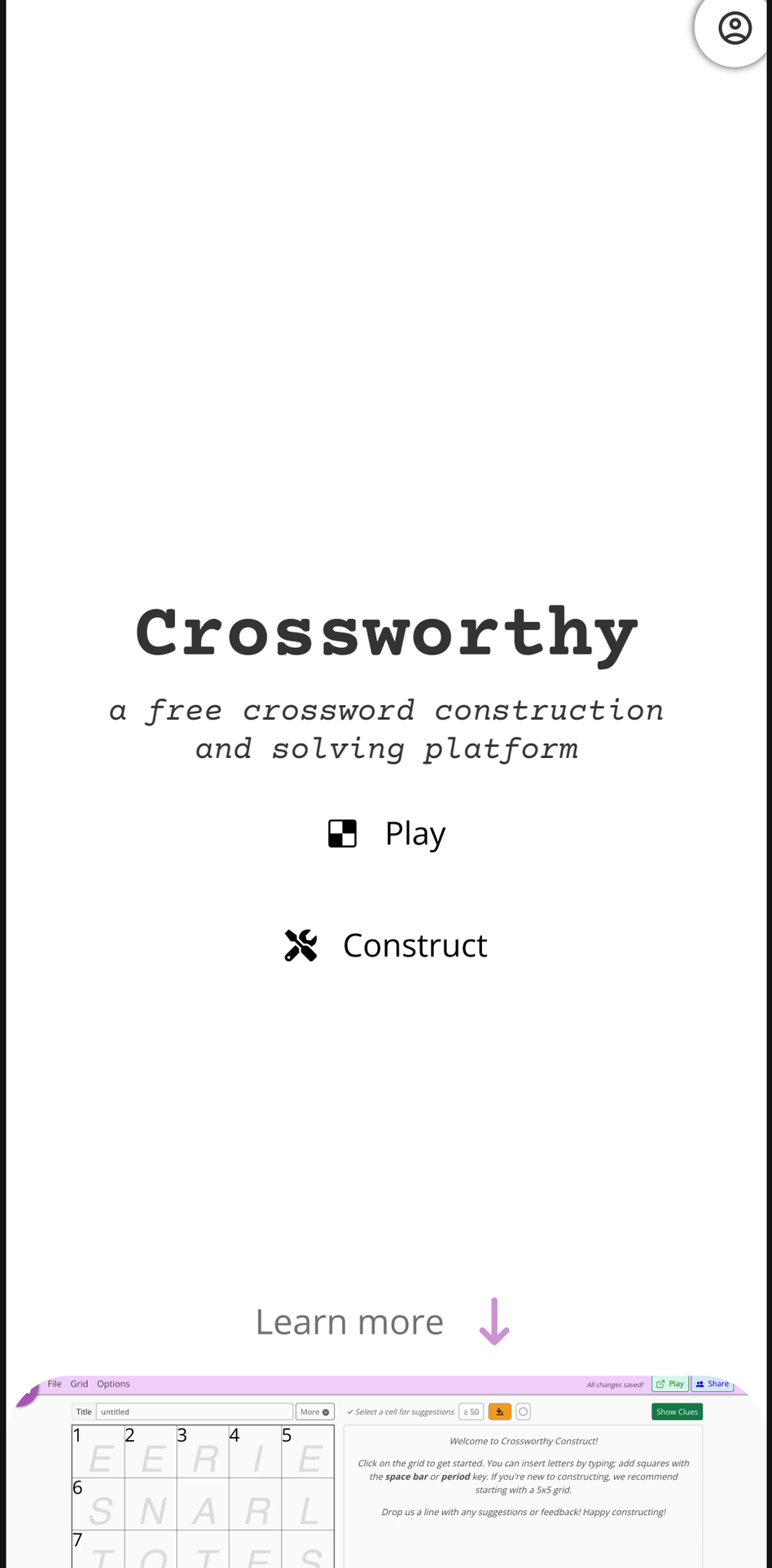
> Disclaimer: I have two crosswords published by the Los Angeles Times. I am not qualified to give advice on how to construct crosswords that may be accepted by other publications, e.g. the New York Times.

What we'll be making

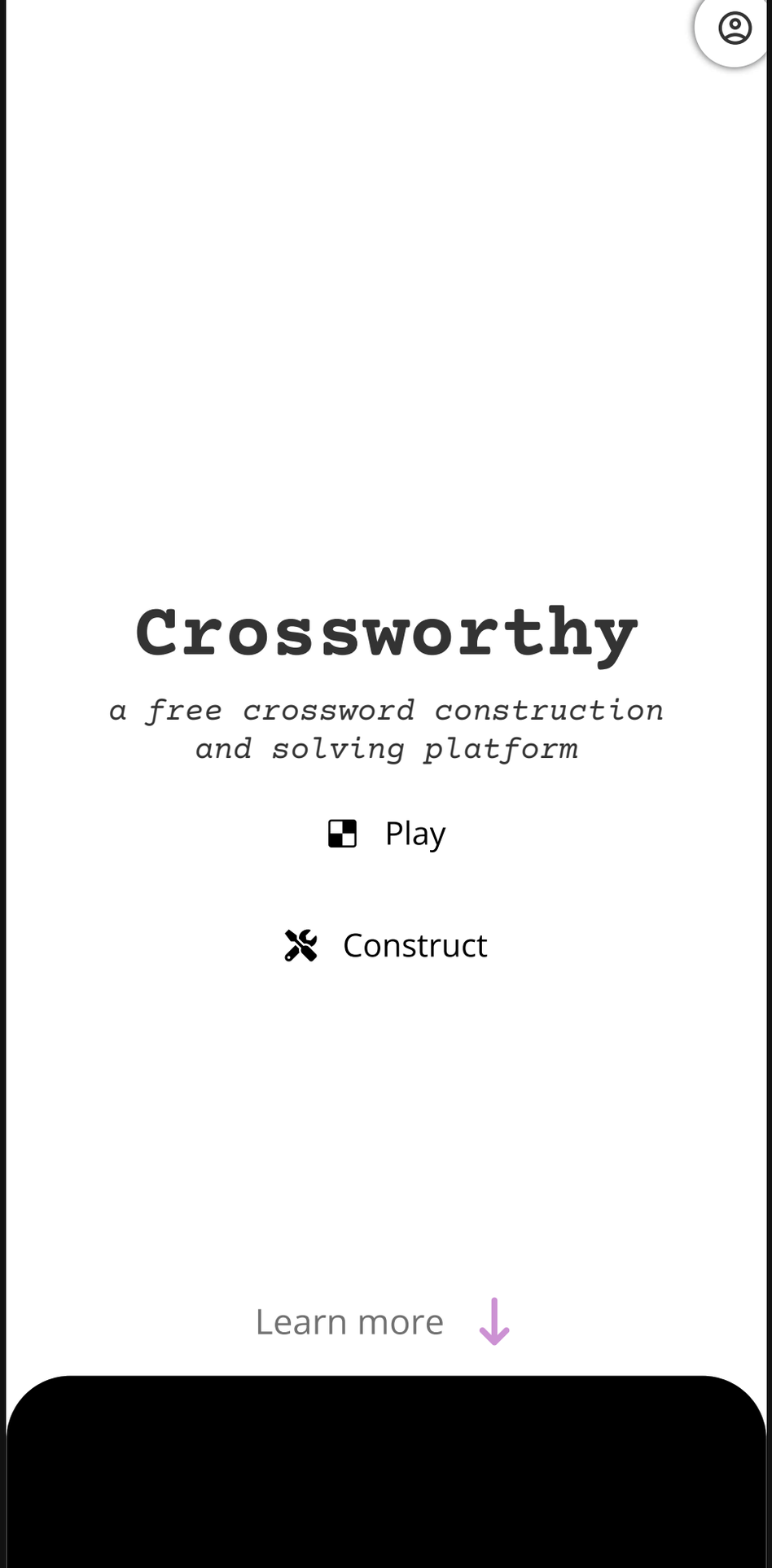
- We'll be constructing a Mini (5x5) crossword.
- The initial entries for this crossword will be the words HELLO and WORLD.
- We will follow a step-by-step process of the crossword construction process.

For convenience, I will be using the web app Crossworthy for this demo. However, I recommend using a dedicated app on your personal computer. My personal app recommendation: Ingrid

Certain slides will contain links to resources. The resources marked with ⭐s are the ones I consider the most valuable.



Let’s Get Started!



Step 0 – Learn

To construct crosswords, you need to know what goes into making a good one. To do this, choose all of the following:

1. Play a range of crosswords. Some crosswords will "feel good", and some will not. You will pick up the rules of crosswords this way.
   - ⭐ Daily Crossword Links
2. Read players' thoughts:
   - ⭐ Crossword Fiend
   - XWord Info ($ after *n* articles)
   - Rex Parker Does the NYT Crossword 🔥
3. Read up on resources for crossword constructors:
   - ⭐ Crossword Publication Specs
   - ⭐ Crossword Constructor's Handbook $
   - ⭐ OLLI Course: Constructing Crosswords
   - ⭐ Wayward Grids (rejected crossword submissions with feedback)

Crossworthy

a free crossword construction and solving platform

Play

Construct

Learn more ↓

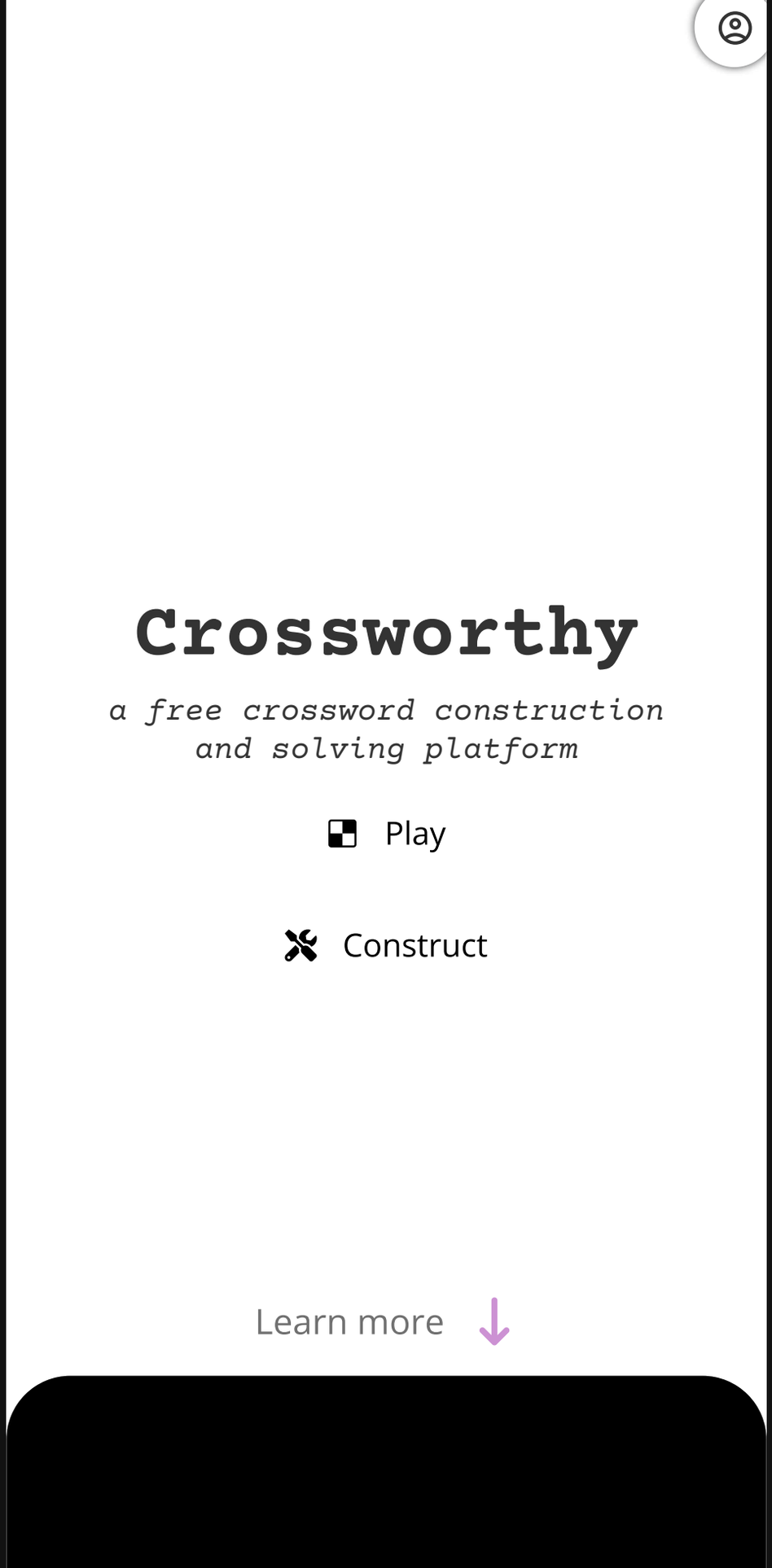
Step 1 – Get a Crossword Construction App

Choose one:

- Crosserville (web)
- Crossword Compiler $ (Windows-only)
- Crossworthy (web)
- ⭐ Ingrid

Alternative options:

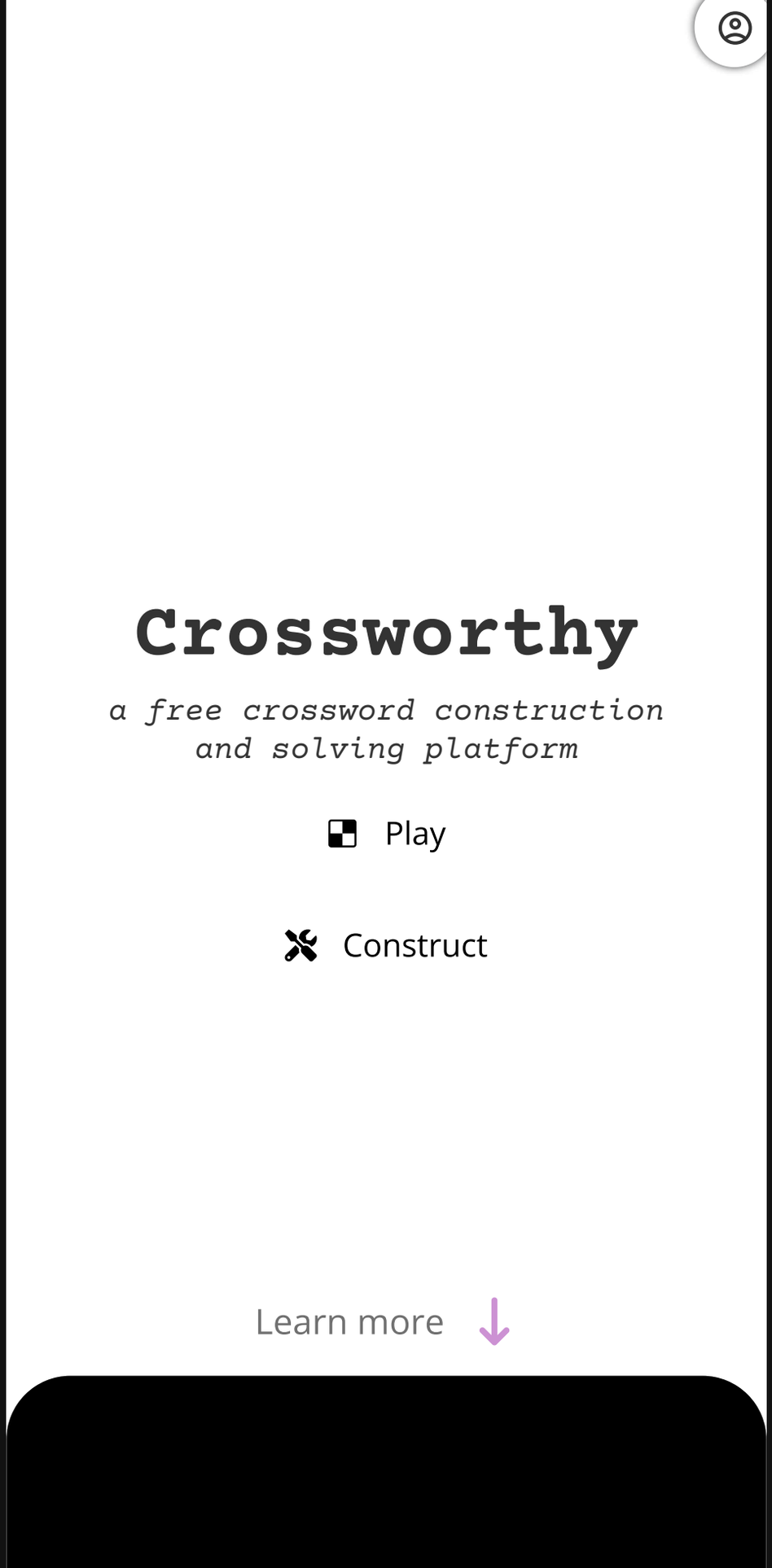
- CrossFire $
- Crosshare (web)



Step 2 – Get a Good Crossword Dictionary

- Crosswords use their own dictionaries, called "word lists".
- Word lists are typically "scored", i.e. more desirable words are given higher priority when finding a fillable grid.
- Higher-quality word lists produce more entertaining puzzles, so getting a good one helps your odds of getting an accepted submission.
- These word lists function as a **starting point**. You *need* to curate word scores instead of assuming the starting point is good enough.

> Note: I score my wordlist using a tagging system. This way, I can rescore all words under a certain tag at once. This is helpful as different types of crosswords prioritize different types of words.



Step 2 – Crossword Dictionaries

High-quality word lists:

- The Collaborative Word List
- Spread the Wordlist
- ⭐ XWord Info Word Lists 💲

Supplemental word lists:

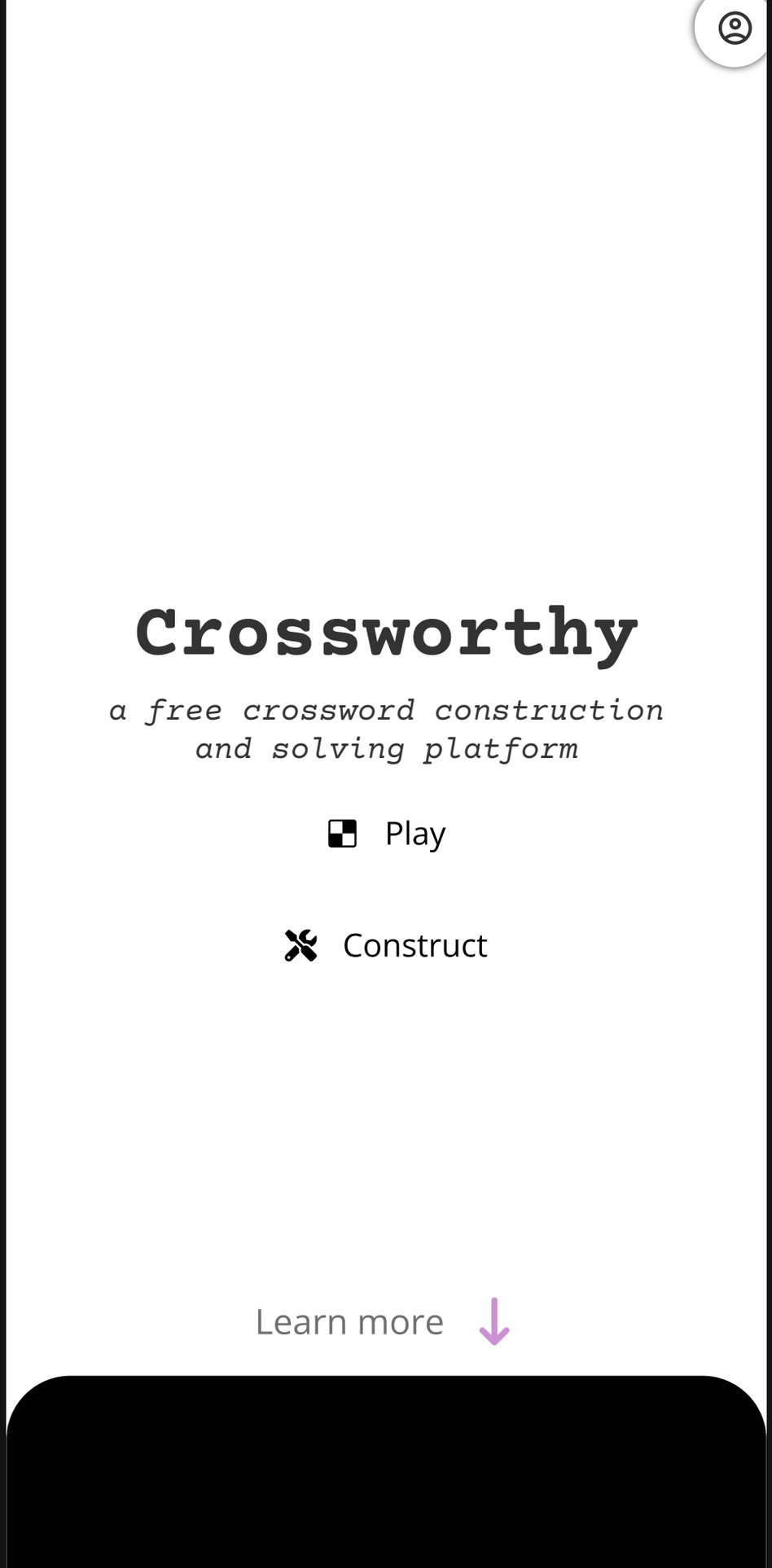
- John Kugelman's Wordlist
  - Modernizes the sensibilities used by the XWord Info Word List.

Other options:

- Matt Abate's Wordlist
- Peter Broda's Wordlist

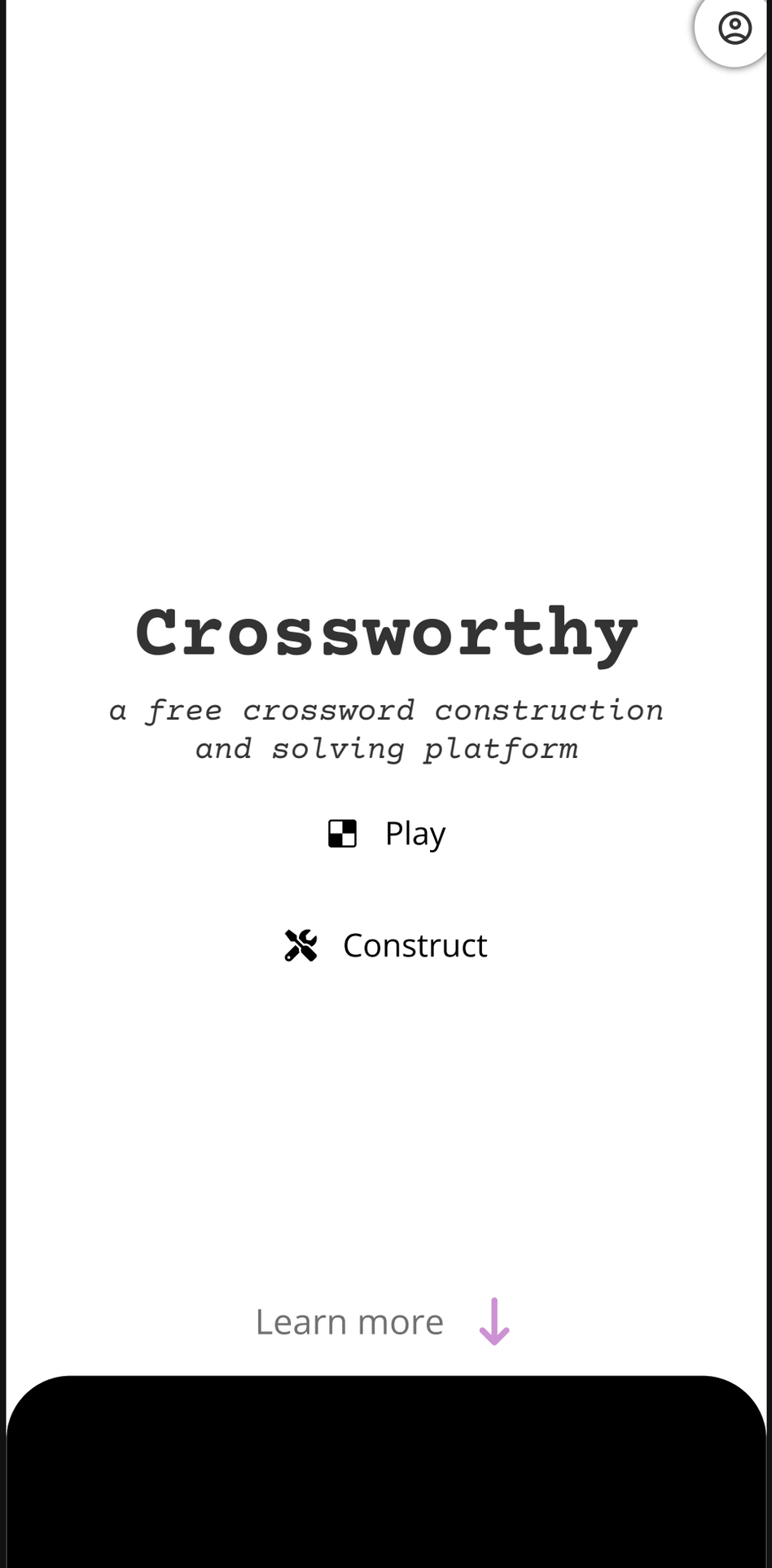
Also:

- Wordlisted
  - Useful for searching through your wordlists.



Step 3 – Set Up Your App

1. Provide the crossword app with your wordlist.
2. Configure your grid accordingly.

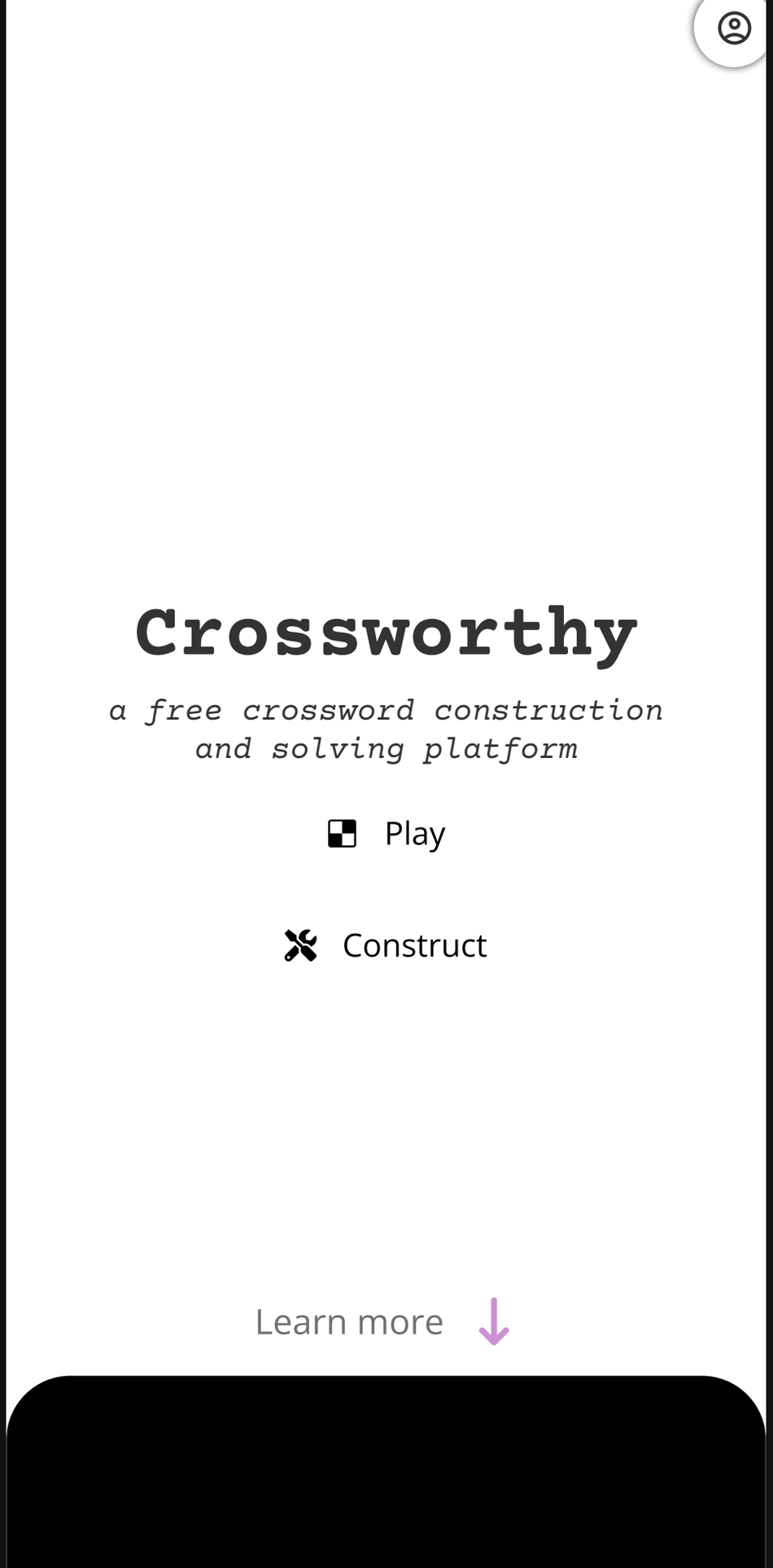


Step 4 – Fill Your Grid

1. Place your theme entries in the grid.
2. Add black squares (within reason) until your grid shows up as fillable.
3. Find "good entries" for each slot.

If you get stuck, try a different arrangement! Failing that, see if lowering the minimum word score helps.

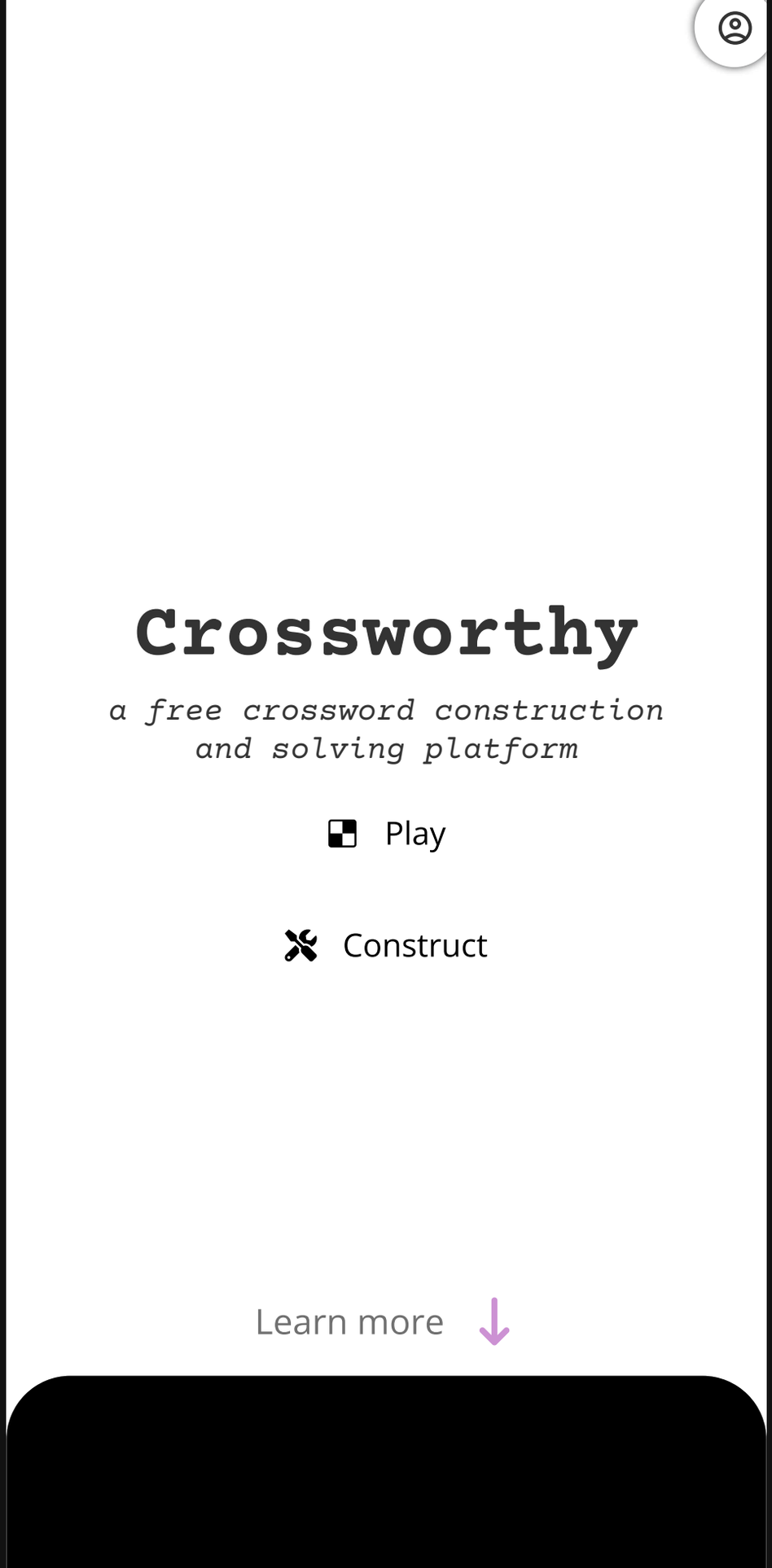
> Note: If you find yourself struggling to make a satisfying grid, consider checking out some of the resources for crossword resources linked to earlier. There is a book's worth of undescribed theory I'm glossing over here.



Step 4 – Fill Your Grid

Make sure your grid is fun to solve for, i.e.:

- A grid should not be unfinishable if they are stumped on a few select words, i.e. the grid should have multiple "paths" into certain areas of the grid.
- No two obscurities should intersect with each other.
- The player should not need specialized knowledge to solve one region of the grid (e.g. all sports clues or all movie clues).
- Don’t use two words that can only be clued as the "same puzzle" (e.g. EAT + ATE). Publishers often extend this to entries that share the same root (e.g. EAT UP and ATE IN).
- You have more fun options for entries the longer they are, so try to strike a balance with how many "short" entries your grid has. E.g. publishers often ask that the # of 3-letter words in a crossword be kept within reasons.



That’s it!

Links to these slides will be available.

Any questions?

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